AMSTERDAM, NETHERLANDS

Van Gogh Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works that put colour, cropping and the work of looking ahead of familiar biographical stories.



The yellow of *Sunflowers* has to distinguish petals, a vase and the surrounding space without relying on large differences of hue. The blue intervals in *Almond Blossom* do a different job, keeping densely described branches open to the air. These are practical painting decisions, and they offer a way into Van Gogh that does not begin by treating every mark as a symptom.

Works by Gauguin, Bernard, Angrand and others broaden the comparison. Van Gogh appears among people making alternative choices, not as a figure working outside artistic exchange. The selection also includes drawings and early subjects whose quieter handling interrupts the expectation that his work must always announce itself through brilliant colour.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/van-gogh-museum

The selection · 20

1. The Potato Eaters
   Vincent van Gogh · 1885
2. Sunflowers
   Vincent van Gogh · January 1889
3. Almond Blossom
   Vincent van Gogh · February 1890
4. Wheatfield with Crows
   Vincent van Gogh · July 1890
5. The Yellow House
   Vincent van Gogh · September 1888
6. Self-Portrait with Grey Felt Hat
   Vincent van Gogh · September–October 1887
7. Van Gogh Painting Sunflowers
   Paul Gauguin · 1888
8. Gauguin's Armchair
   Vincent van Gogh · 1888
9. The Pink Peach Tree
   Vincent van Gogh · 1888
10. Café Table with Absinthe
    Vincent van Gogh · 1887
11. Phryne
    Gustave Boulanger · 1850
12. The Seine, Morning at Saint-Ouen
    Charles Angrand · 1886
13. Self-Portrait with a Portrait of Gauguin
    Émile Bernard · 1888
14. Haymaking at Éragny
    Camille Pissarro · 1887
15. Woman Picking Up a Stick before Trees
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890
16. Coal Mine in the Borinage
    Vincent van Gogh · 1879
17. The Bedroom
    Vincent van Gogh · October 1888
18. Irises
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890
19. Shoes
    Vincent van Gogh · 1886
20. View of Arles with Irises in the Foreground
    Vincent van Gogh · 1888

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The Potato Eaters

Vincent van Gogh

1885 · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. The Potato Eaters. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The lamp gathers five people into a small area of shared light. Angular hands connect their faces to the dish, making the meal a physical activity rather than a posed family assembly. Van Gogh's brown-green interior keeps the figures bound to their surroundings. The roughness is distributed across the whole scene, not reserved as a character trait for one sitter.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Sunflowers

Vincent van Gogh

January 1889 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Sunflowers. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: Google Arts & Culture — hwEGmsM-FoHAwA. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The bouquet includes flowers that stand up and others that droop, with dark seed heads interrupting the yellow. These differences prevent the restricted palette from becoming uniform. Van Gogh gives each stage and direction a place within the arrangement. The subject's familiarity can hide the painting's demanding problem: making many distinct forms legible through closely related colours.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0031V1962

03 / 20

Almond Blossom

Vincent van Gogh

February 1890 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Almond Blossom. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: dAFXSL9sZ1ulDw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The tree's trunk and larger surroundings are excluded, leaving branches and the spaces between them to organise the image. The museum identifies the painting as a gift for Van Gogh's newborn nephew. That occasion matters, but it does not replace the visual construction: pale flowers remain distinct because the blue ground gives their intricate network room.

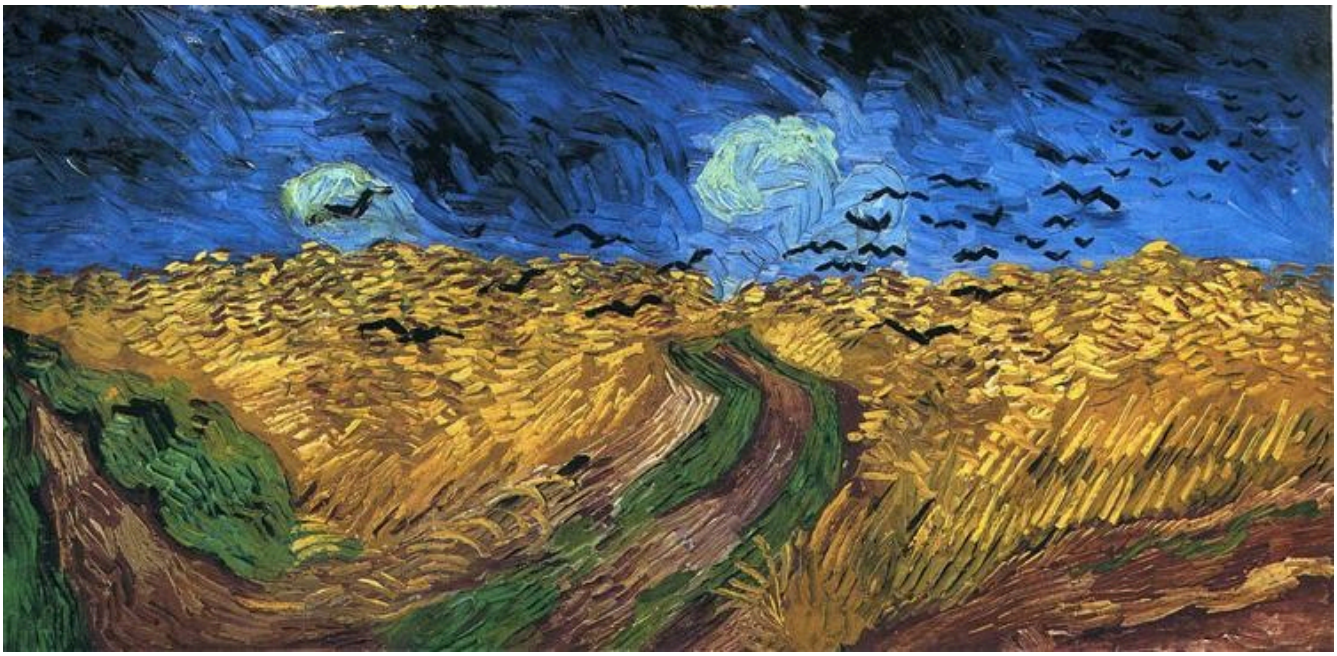
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0176V1962

04 / 20

Wheatfield with Crows

Vincent van Gogh

July 1890 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Wheatfield with Crows. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The paths offer competing routes into the wheat, while dark birds and forceful marks keep the sky active. These features sustain tension without needing the story that this was Van Gogh's final painting. The museum rejects that persistent claim. Reading the work as a predetermined farewell can close down the more specific choices that make the landscape difficult to settle.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0149V1962

05 / 20

The Yellow House

Vincent van Gogh

September 1888 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. The Yellow House (The Street). Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: Van Gogh Museum. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The yellow building is easy to identify against the deep blue sky, but it does not stand alone. Neighbours, pedestrians and open street keep it within a functioning town. Van Gogh gives a particular residence a strong colour identity without clearing away its ordinary surroundings. The place remains part of a larger street even as it becomes the picture's named subject.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0032V1962

06 / 20

Self-Portrait with Grey Felt Hat

Vincent van Gogh

September–October 1887 · Oil on cotton · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Self-Portrait with Grey Felt Hat. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh; Source credit: PgEJ1hPIzqsM2w at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Short strokes change direction around the hat, face and clothing. Orange in the beard answers cooler passages nearby, so the likeness depends on contrasts extending beyond the features themselves. Van Gogh makes the surrounding space participate in describing the head. The portrait is an experiment in how paint can organise a face, not simply a disclosure of temperament.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0016V1962

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Van Gogh Painting Sunflowers

Paul Gauguin

1888 · Van Gogh Museum



Paul Gauguin. Van Gogh Painting Sunflowers. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Gauguin shows a painter occupied with a task, his bent arm connecting the activity to the flowers beside him. The broad colour areas give this Van Gogh a setting different from the restless strokes of his own self-portraits. A fellow artist's image is an interpretation too. It should not be treated as an unfiltered view behind Van Gogh's paintings.

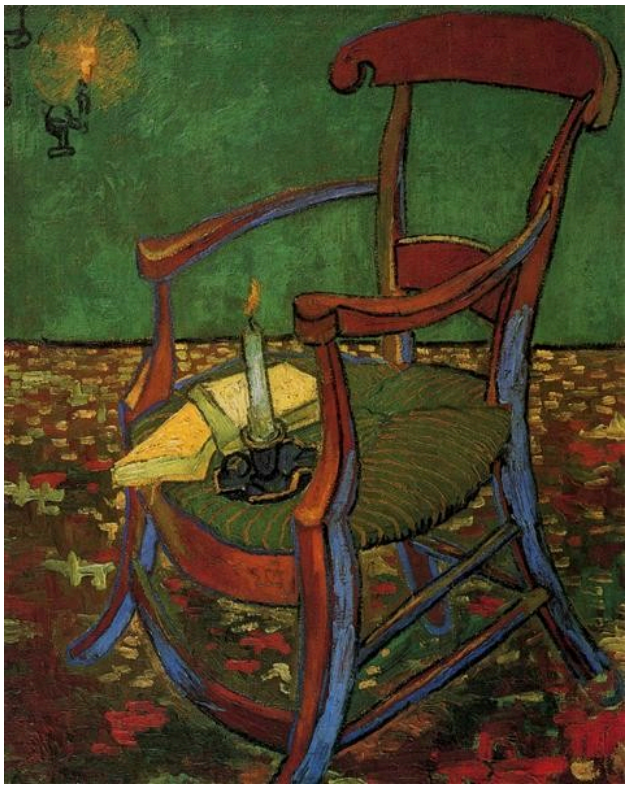
Object source · Open artwork

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Gauguin's Armchair

Vincent van Gogh

1888 · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Paul Gauguin's Armchair. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Books and a burning candle occupy the empty seat, making absence specific without supplying a painted person. The curved furniture, green wall and patterned floor provide the image's bodily and colour relationships. Van Gogh lets chosen objects carry some of a portrait's work. The chair can suggest its named sitter without becoming a complete account of his personality.

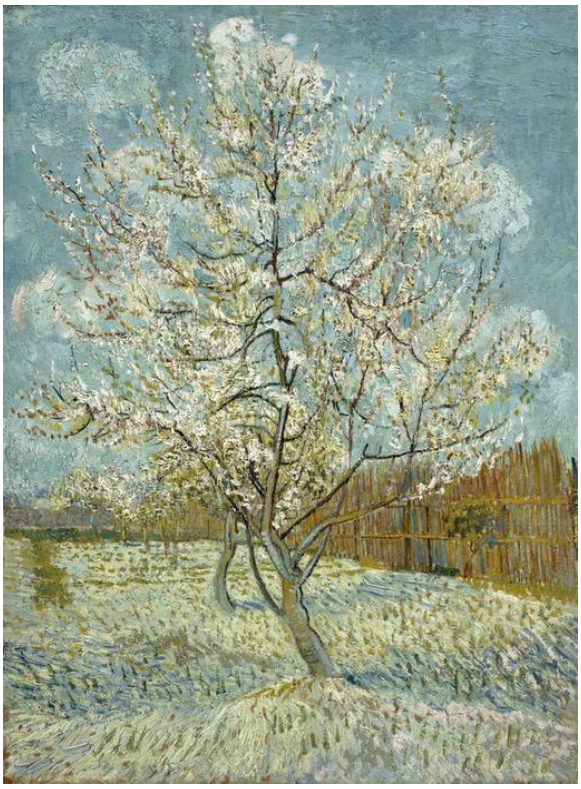
Object source · Open artwork

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The Pink Peach Tree

Vincent van Gogh

1888 · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. The pink peach tree. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The blossom is dispersed rather than painted as one pale canopy. Gaps keep the slim branches readable against the sky, with fencing and smaller trunks locating the tree in an orchard. Van Gogh balances close attention to a single growth with enough context to prevent isolation. The open structure matters as much as the accumulation of flower marks.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0025V1962

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Café Table with Absinthe

Vincent van Gogh

1887 · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Café table with absinth. Image credit: Vincent van Gogh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The glass and carafe stand before another transparent surface, the window. Reflections and the street beyond complicate a simple division between near objects and distant background. Van Gogh makes looking through and looking at occur together. The café table is a compact setting for a problem that extends beyond its few objects: transparency can disclose space while also interrupting it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0186V1962

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Phryne

Gustave Boulanger

1850 · Van Gogh Museum



Gustave Boulanger. Phryne. Image credit: Gustave Boulanger. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Boulanger's carefully shaded skin and cushioned setting produce a body with a different kind of finish from Van Gogh's figures. The raised hand and reclining pose belong to a staged presentation, not an interrupted household task. Compare the handling without treating one approach as an automatic improvement over the other. Each asks paint to serve a distinct ideal of representation.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

The Seine, Morning at Saint-Ouen

Charles Angrand

1886 · Van Gogh Museum



Charles Angrand. The Seine, Morning (Saint-Ouen). Image credit: Charles Angrand. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The broad river offers few incidents to seize attention. Angrand instead works with small shifts within pale, closely related tones, giving the water a surface that is quiet without being blank. Trees and buildings define a low distance. The picture provides a useful counterweight to stronger colour contrasts: restraint still requires numerous discriminating decisions.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0524S2012

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Self-Portrait with a Portrait of Gauguin

Émile Bernard

1888 · Van Gogh Museum



Émile Bernard. Self-Portrait with Portrait of Gauguin. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/emile-bernard/self-portrait-with-portrait-of-gauguin-1888 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Bernard places his cropped face beside a smaller image of Gauguin, but the two likenesses do not pretend to occupy one continuous space. Pale blue connects them across that difference. Self-description here includes another artist's presence. The relationship is made through the arrangement of images rather than through a scene showing the men together.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Haymaking at Éragny

Camille Pissarro

1887 · Van Gogh Museum



Camille Pissarro. The Harvest of Hay in Eragny. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The workers' movements recur among the haystacks, giving the field a pattern of repeated labour. Pissarro carries small coloured marks across people and ground, binding their activities to the landscape's construction. The figures remain recognisable without receiving an entirely different manner of painting. Compare how Van Gogh separates a bending body from trees in the following drawing.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Woman Picking Up a Stick before Trees

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Chalk on paper · Van Gogh Museum



A Woman Picking Up a Stick in Front of Trees. WikiArt; Vincent van Gogh. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sharp bend of the body makes the action clear before the surrounding foliage has been sorted out. Different stroke directions then distinguish clothing, trunks and leaves. Van Gogh keeps the drawing open while supplying enough information for the task to register. Economy concerns selecting the necessary marks, not simply using fewer of them everywhere.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Coal Mine in the Borinage

Vincent van Gogh

1879 · Pencil and watercolour on paper · Van Gogh Museum



Coalmine in the Borinage. WikiArt; Vincent van Gogh. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Low buildings and smoking chimneys spread across a spare landscape. The small figures establish a human scale before the industrial structures. This early work directs attention to a setting of labour without the bright palette that later became closely associated with Van Gogh. Its inclusion keeps the working environment visible as a subject, rather than reducing his development to a change in colour.

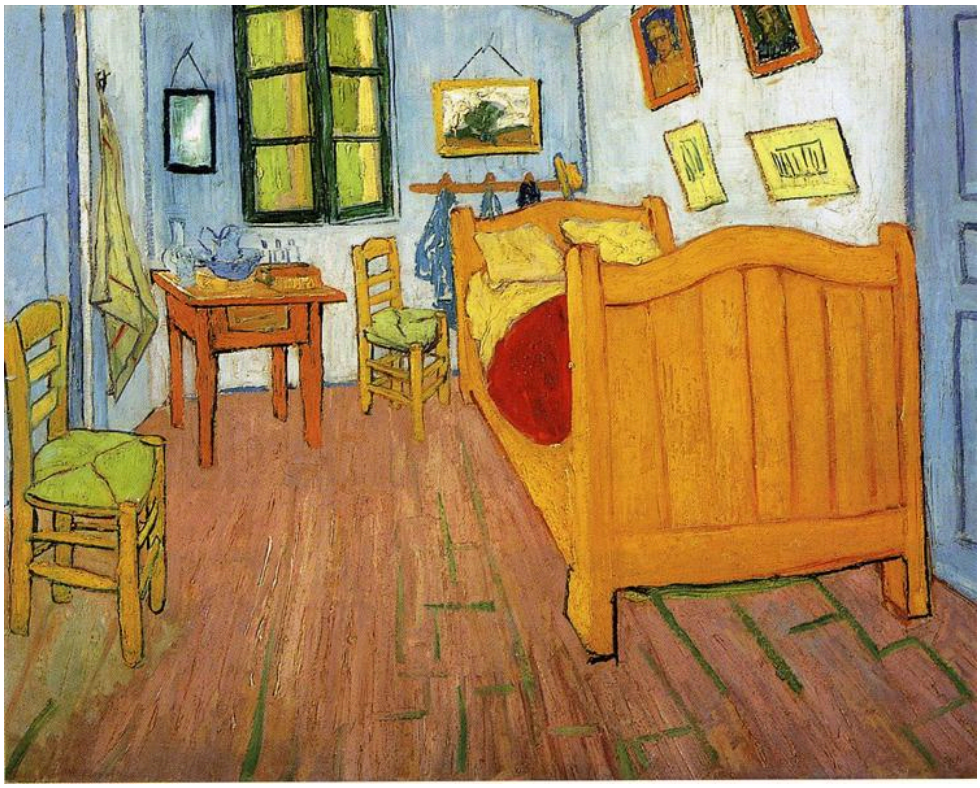
Object source · Open artwork

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The Bedroom

Vincent van Gogh

October 1888 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh, The Bedroom, 1888. Reproduction via WikiArt; source label: Public domain. · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The large bed and two chairs leave the room with little uncommitted space. Angled furniture and hanging pictures keep its simplified geometry conspicuous. Van Gogh makes an inhabited interior from strong boundaries and colour relationships rather than a neutral architectural measurement. This Amsterdam painting is the 1888 version; later painted versions and the related letter sketches should not be conflated with it.

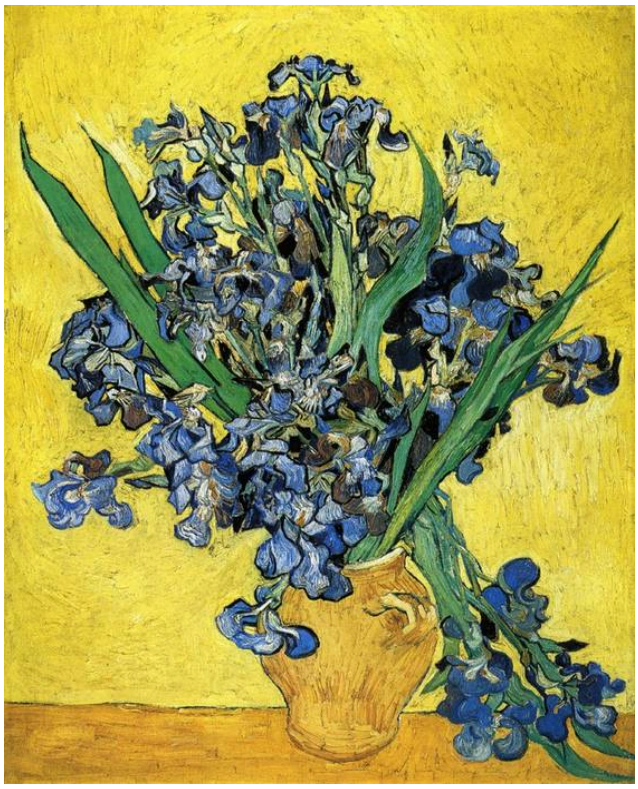
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: s0047V1962

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Irises

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Still Life with Irises. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/vincent-van-gogh/still-life-with-irises-1890 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The flowers push out against yellow, with pointed leaves and falling stems breaking the bouquet's boundary. Their present blue is not exactly the colour relationship Van Gogh painted: fading red pigment has shifted the irises from violet towards blue. The contrast remains strong, but the material history matters. A reproduction records the painting's present condition, not an unchanged original decision.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Shoes

Vincent van Gogh

1886 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. A Pair of Shoes. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/vincent-van-gogh/a-pair-of-shoes-1886 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The shoes face the viewer at different angles, exposing worn leather, openings and laces. Van Gogh gives them enough space to become a subject without identifying a wearer or constructing an anecdote. Signs of use are visible; a complete life story is not. The concentration of attention is comparable to portraiture even though the objects cannot return a gaze.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

View of Arles with Irises in the Foreground

Vincent van Gogh

1888 · Oil on canvas · Van Gogh Museum



Vincent van Gogh. View of Arles with Irises in the Foreground. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/vincent-van-gogh/view-of-arles-with-irises-in-the-foreground-1888 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Near flowers lead into bands of cultivated land and then the distant town. Van Gogh does not sacrifice the foreground's active pattern to make that depth readable. Repeated colour areas establish the passage, while trees interrupt the remote line. The irises belong simultaneously to a close study of growth and to a much larger account of place.

Object source · Open artwork

Let the comparison stay specific

Follow a single choice across a few works: the space between branches, the treatment of hands, or the direction of strokes. Biography can then enter where evidence makes it relevant. Consult current museum information for display and access; collection membership does not guarantee that every selected work will be available on one visit.

Further reading

Vincent van Gogh: The Letters

Vincent van Gogh; edited by Leo Jansen, Hans Luijten and Nienke Bakker · Read free · English translations and original texts

The Van Gogh Museum and Huygens Institute's edition of the letters includes original texts, English translations, images and scholarly notes. Search by artwork to compare what Van Gogh actually wrote with later interpretations of his paintings.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
